One speaks more and more of a war that will last for a full year. Quite a somber view of the future. For now, the hostage deal is very encouraging. Otherwise, the daily announcements on television of the names and pictures of soldiers and officers killed are very depressing. I remember that the same daily postings in newspapers took place during the “war of attrition” of 1969–70 until they were stopped because of their impact on the population.

Watching the endless march of tens of thousands of Palestinians evacuated from the northern to the southern part of the Gaza Strip is heart-wrenching. They proceed slowly, carrying whatever they can, in a dense procession of the dispossessed. Soldiers are watching the march to find any Israeli hostages. To no avail. According to the army, almost all inhabitants of northern Gaza have moved to the South.

Of course, Ben-Gvir and Smotrich are against the hostage deal. It won’t change anything, but how long shall we have to suffer the revolting presence of these two freaks?

Wednesday, November 22

The Israeli Cabinet has agreed to the ceasefire and hostages exchange with Hamas. According to Hamas, the ceasefire is supposed to start tomorrow (Thursday, November 23) at 10:00 a.m. Let us keep our fingers crossed. Many of us hope that it will happen and that it can be followed by further days without fighting in exchange for further releases, but naturally we worry lest some incident impedes the process. The head of Mossad is in Qatar and tonight he will get the list of hostages to be liberated. Yet the names will not be released before their formal identification tomorrow, to avoid any disappointments. Netanyahu declared that the liberation of a further group of hostages is not certain at the moment.

In the government session that approved the exchange, Smotrich and Religious Zionist ministers decided to vote in favor. The finance minister